

St. Basil's Cathedral

Ivan the Terrible's unparalleled, colorful 16th-century Orthodox church named after a Muscovite shoemaker and saint



In 1554, the first Czar of Russia, Ivan Vasilyevich—known as Ivan the Terrible—ordered work to begin on the construction of a cathedral to honor his conquest of the independent khanates of Kazan and Astrakhan. The cathedral was completed in 1561 and was officially known as the Cathedral of the Intercession of the Virgin on the Moat, because it was built on the moat that separated the Kremlin (see pp.150–151) from the town. It is more popularly known as St. Basil's, after the "Holy Fool," Basil the Blessed, who was buried in the church after his death in 1557. Legend says the Czar blinded the cathedral's architect, Postnik Yakovlev, to prevent him from building a more beautiful church.

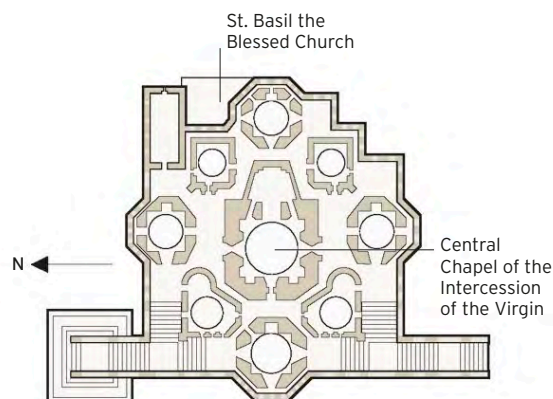
Religious and secular uses

Set on white stone foundations, St. Basil's was built in red brick around an internal wooden frame; where stone was used, it was painted to look like brick. Its onion domes were originally hemispherical and gilded; the cathedral's bright colors were added from the 17th century on. Later, its interior was also covered with intricate murals and icons. St. Basil's survived many fires and escaped the destruction planned by Napoleon's army in 1812 and Stalin's regime in the 20th century. A museum since 1929, it now forms part of the Red Square and Kremlin World Heritage Site. Religious services are held once a year on the Day of the Intercession in October.

St. Basil's **symbolized** the Bible's **Heavenly City**, depicted as a **turreted citadel** in old manuscripts

THE CATHEDRAL'S CHAPELS

The cathedral complex is composed of nine chapels. The Central Chapel of the Intercession of the Virgin is the largest, rising to an internal height of 151ft (46m). Four large chapels are aligned to the points of the compass, and four smaller chapels are raised on platforms. The chapel dedicated to St. Basil was added in 1588.



△ ONION DOMES

An aerial view shows the chapels' onion domes, the tented tower of the belfry (top right), and the green-roofed galleries that connect the buildings.

